

Attribution Methodology Whitepaper

RelayFox click-based order attribution for broadcasts and automated flows. Version 1.3.

PUBLISHED	January 15, 2026	METHOD OWNER	RelayFox Data Science
DEFAULT MODEL	Last eligible SMS/MMS click	VIEW-THROUGH	Disabled
RECONCILIATION	Daily for 14 days	CURRENCY	Store presentment currency

Corpus notice: This is a synthetic demonstration document created for Cortex Search evaluation. Brand names, people, metrics, URLs, short codes, and incidents are fictional.

1. Purpose and scope

RelayFox attribution answers a specific operational question: which delivered SMS or MMS message most recently generated an eligible customer click before an order? It is designed for consistent campaign reporting, not as proof of causal incrementality. Holdouts, geo tests, or randomized experiments are required to estimate incremental lift.

2. Eligible events and identity

- **Delivery:** The message must have a successful delivery event. Failed and filtered messages are ineligible.
- **Click:** The customer must click a RelayFox-tracked branded link inside the configured click window. HELP, privacy, terms, and preference-center links are excluded.
- **Identity:** RelayFox resolves the click to an order using normalized phone, authenticated checkout/session, or an approved identity bridge. Shared household devices do not create attribution without a customer-level match.
- **Order:** The order must be paid or authorized, not a test, and inside the applicable order window. Tax and shipping are excluded from net attributed revenue; discounts and refunds reduce it.

3. Default windows

Program type	Click window from delivery	Order window from eligible click	Typical use
Broadcast campaign	24 hours	5 days	Flash sale, product launch, newsletter, VIP drop
Automated flow	7 days	7 days	Welcome, abandoned cart, back in stock, winback
Transactional message	Not attributed by default	Not attributed by default	Order, shipping, delivery, account alerts

A brand may shorten windows for reporting, but extending beyond 7 days requires Data Governance approval. Window changes apply prospectively and are stored with campaign configuration.

4. Credit assignment

When multiple eligible SMS/MMS clicks precede an order, RelayFox credits the most recent eligible click. Broadcast and flow messages compete under the same rule. Credit is not split. Other marketing platforms may independently claim the same order because cross-channel deduplication is outside the standard RelayFox model.

Time	Event	Eligibility outcome
Aug 22, 2025 5:34 PM	Trailhead Flash Sale delivered	Starts 24-hour broadcast click window
Aug 22, 2025 6:02 PM	Customer clicks Trailhead link	Eligible; starts 5-day order window
Aug 23, 2025 9:10 AM	Cart Flow message delivered and clicked	More recent eligible SMS click
Aug 23, 2025 9:42 AM	Order JC-784193 placed for \$146.00 net merchandise	Credited to Cart Flow, not Trailhead broadcast

5. Revenue calculation

Net attributed revenue = item subtotal - item discounts - refunded item value. Tax, shipping, duties, tips, gift-card tender, and post-purchase upsells not present in the attributed checkout are excluded. Partial refunds reduce revenue during reconciliation but do not remove the order count unless the full merchandise value is refunded.

For the Q3 Trailhead Flash Sale, the first-day dashboard showed \$294,180. After 14-day reconciliation, \$5,910 of refunds, \$1,120 of duplicate-order cleanup, and \$410 of test/fraud exclusions produced the final \$286,740 reported in RF-CB-001 and RF-QBR-008.

6. Broadcast versus flow reporting

Dimension	Broadcast	Automated flow
Primary denominator	Delivered messages	Flow entrants and delivered messages by step
Default click window	24 hours	7 days
Default order window	5 days after click	7 days after click
Common KPI	Revenue per delivered message	Revenue per entrant and per delivered step
Repeat exposure	One campaign plus optional reminder	Multiple sequenced steps until exit
Typical caveat	Short urgency can overlap cart recovery	Longer windows increase overlap with broadcasts

7. Reporting latency and revisions

- Click and delivery events normally appear within 5 minutes.
- Shopify orders normally appear within 10 minutes, but webhook or platform incidents can delay ingestion.
- Refunds and cancellations reconcile daily for 14 days. Reports are marked Preliminary until day 15.
- Identity merges can move credit between campaigns when stronger customer evidence arrives. The audit log preserves the prior assignment.
- Dashboard exports include report_generated_at, attribution_version, and window configuration for reproducibility.

8. Limitations and recommended experiments

Attributed revenue is not the same as incremental revenue. Customers may have purchased without the message, especially in cart and back-in-stock flows. RelayFox recommends a 5%-10% randomized holdout for large broadcasts and a persistent 5% flow holdout when volume permits. Compare net revenue per eligible customer, not only revenue per message.

9. Audit example

Field	Example value
order_id	JC-784193
attributed_message_id	JC-CART-STEP2-20250823-0910
prior_competing_message	JC-BRD-2025-0822-TRAILHEAD
click_timestamp_utc	2025-08-23T16:10:22Z
order_timestamp_utc	2025-08-23T16:42:07Z
net_attributed_revenue	146.00 USD
attribution_rule	FLOW_LAST_CLICK_V1_3